



KCAC Position Statement: Proper Labeling of Kratom Products

Kratom is a product possessing potential benefits but also some health risks.¹ Proper labeling is a key to communicate information the consumer needs to determine whether to use the product and how to do so safely.² Ambiguity can lead consumers to make uninformed decisions about using kratom, using one product versus another, or selecting the right dose for their purposes.²

We are aware of products being sold in bags or baggies, with no label at all, or with only the product name written with a sharpie. This makes it virtually impossible to issue a targeted recall if health issues such as contamination or adulteration are discovered or to hold companies accountable. All dietary supplement products are required to collect information of adverse events reported to them and to alert the FDA right away if a serious adverse event is reported.³ However, this is impossible if there is no contact information for the company.

We are aware of labels containing no serving size or instructions for use. There are liquid products that have multiple servings per small container, but no way to reliably measure out the specified dose. There are products with more concentrated alkaloid delivery per mL or g than in traditional whole leaf products, increasing the risk of unintentional over-exposure. Many products we assessed do not specifically warn consumers that kratom could be habit forming. These vulnerabilities can lead to consumers taking more kratom than is intended and having an adverse event or unpleasant experience as a result.

There may be kratom products processed and produced using shared equipment with other herbal products, or where kratom is mixed with foods (flour, sugar, chocolate, animal or plant extracts, etc), as well as flavorings and colorings.⁴ This poses a risk of allergic reactions for at risk consumers which should be disclosed so they know to avoid those products.⁴

In our first position statement, we specifically recommend against the sale of kratom products to people under the age of 21 with age verification for purchase because children and younger adults are at a higher risk of addiction.⁵ This should be reflected on the label to make the age restriction clear. Pregnant or breastfeeding women using kratom may also place their fetus or newborn children at risk of kratom addiction and of significant kratom withdrawal.¹ Women of childbearing potential, whether pregnant or not, have a lower interim reference level for heavy metals because of the sensitivity that these elemental impurities have on the developing brains of fetuses and newborns.^{6,7} Kratom products may be delivering too much heavy metal exposure to pregnant or breastfeeding individuals.^{6,7} Few products warn pregnant or breastfeeding women not to use the products.

Kratom has the potential to work along with other drugs to produce a greater response than they did before.¹ This would be potentially risky for some consumers, but without alerting their clinician about their use, these drug interactions cannot be prevented.



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Unless a learned body like the National Academies, CDC, or NIH specify that a dietary supplement can treat, cure or prevent a disease or disorder, they are barred by federal law from promoting the product for that purpose.³ Companies would need to alert the FDA of their intent to make an actual health claim for their product and give the FDA 120-days to review it. Dietary supplements are only allowed to make quasi-health claims, whereby they say their product can promote some aspect of well-being if they specify that the FDA did not evaluate these quasi-health claims and that the product is not intended to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease.³

The GKCAC believes that every kratom product label:

- Complies with federal requirements for allergen labeling.
- Clearly provides:
 - The name and place of business of the processor.
 - A declaration that the product contains whole leaf kratom or a kratom extract, and disclosure of any other dietary supplement ingredient included in the product.
 - Directions for use that include:
 - A recommended amount of the kratom product per serving (for example: *"½ tablet per serving"*).
 - The recommended number of servings that can be safely consumed in a twenty-four-hour period (for example, *"½ tablet per serving taken no more than 2 times in a 24-hour period"*).
 - Quantitative declarations of the amount of total kratom alkaloids, mitragynine, and 7-hydroxymitragynine provided per serving (for example, *"One serving will provide 50 mcg of total alkaloids, 28 mcg of mitragynine and 0.5mcg of 7-hydroxymitragynine"*).
 - The total number of servings per container. (for example: *"This bottle contains 2 servings"*).
- Clearly and conspicuously provides the following four warnings:
 - *"The product may be habit-forming."*
 - *"The product is not recommended for individuals under the age of 21, or who are pregnant or breastfeeding."*
 - *"These statements have not been evaluated by the United States Food and Drug Administration. This product is not intended to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease."*
 - *"Kratom may interact with certain medications and substances, consult a healthcare practitioner prior to use."*

The GKCAC recommends the following:

- A calibrated measuring device is included if the product is in a liquid form and contains more than three servings per retail container.



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References:

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